

To: Dr. Michael Hahn

Email: mhahn@lst.uni-saarland.de

Subject: Application for PhD in LaCoCo Lab — LLM Theory & Interpretability — Nauval Zulfikar

Dear Dr. Hahn,

I am writing to express my keen interest in the PhD position at the LaCoCo Lab, focusing on LLM Theory & Interpretability. I am particularly drawn to the opportunity to work under your guidance at Saarland University, given your pioneering work in the field of computational cognition and language model interpretability.

I am available to start the PhD program on 1 September 2026, aligning with the flexible start date mentioned in the position details.

Your paper, "[TODO: verify supervisor paper title via Google Scholar]," has been instrumental in shaping my understanding of the intricate mechanisms underlying language models. The insights into model interpretability and the potential to bridge computational cognition with neuroscience are particularly inspiring and align with my research aspirations.

In terms of relevant experience, my MSc dissertation at Aston University, titled "Enhancing Supply Chain Information Sharing Systems Through Blockchain: Integrated Customer Reviews LLM Analysis," involved fine-tuning the DeBERTa-v3 transformer model. This project honed my skills in transformer fine-tuning and system integration, directly relevant to the themes of LLM theory and interpretability.

Additionally, my role as a Data Scientist & Project Manager at the Public Works & Spatial Planning Department involved designing ETL pipelines and implementing data governance practices. This experience has equipped me with a robust understanding of data management and model reliability, essential for conducting research in mechanistically reverse-engineering model internals.

I acknowledge that my academic background is in Business Analytics rather than pure Computer Science. However, my work experience and projects, such as the LLM-Generated Adaptive Shipper Decision Rules, demonstrate my capability to apply machine learning and NLP techniques effectively.

I have attached my CV, transcripts, and a motivation statement referencing recent LaCoCo publications for your review. I am eager to contribute to your lab's research and am confident that my skills and experiences align well with the position's requirements.

Thank you for considering my application. I look forward to the possibility of discussing my application further.

Sincerely,

Nauval Zulfikar

zulfikar.nauval1998@gmail.com | +44 7300 469048 | nauvalzulfikar.vercel.app